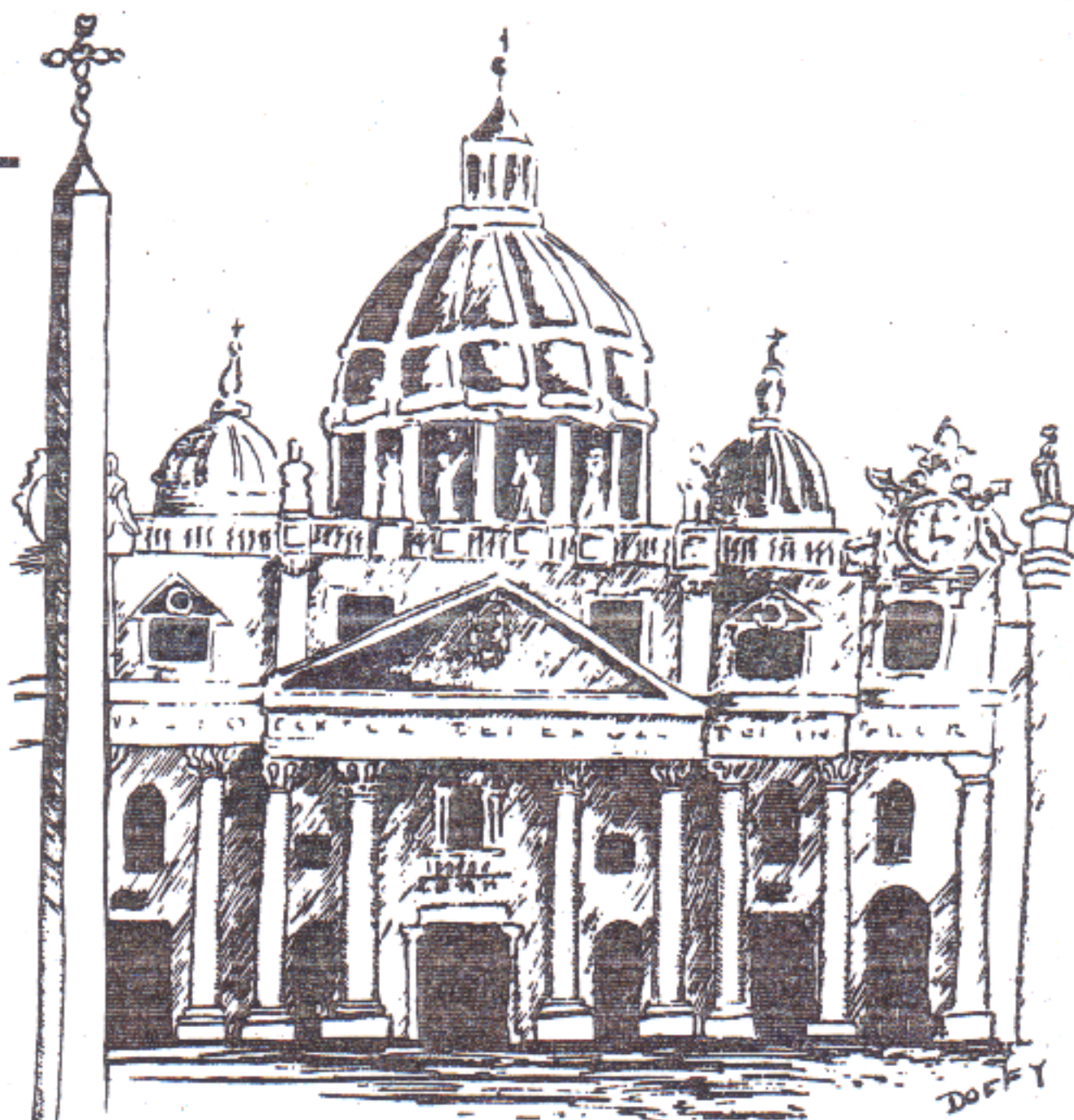


MARCH 29, 1952

The Incredible Italians

P. M. PASINETTI



MANY Americans who were in Italy during the war and many who have gone there since have had the impression they were discovering an unknown country. They knew of the proverbial "culture" of Italy but such knowledge in most cases had no concrete human connotations. It has them now.

War brings people brutally in touch with the countries to which it sends them; but along with its infinitely lamentable aspects there are vague positive elements deriving from the fact that war generally leaves time and opportunity only for essential human relationships; thus sometimes it seems to foster a special intensity and integrity of feeling in the very midst of its horror, ravage, and boredom. Speaking of such matters, one is always aware of the grave dangers of sentimentalization: for example, idyllic pictures of G.I.'s and Italian girls have probably been as numerous in fiction and films since the Second World War—and as rich in clichés—as those of soldiers and French nurses were after the First. But there has been more than that; and it seems certain that to some Americans the human contacts and experiences in Italy have been an important catalyzing element in their own self-clarification. Some successful novels, like John

Horne Burns's "The Gallery," are cases in point.

Hence also the interest in new Italian literature. A considerable number of Italian novels have been translated into English in recent years. Some outstanding titles are Alberto Moravia's "The Woman of Rome," "Two Adolescents," "Conjugal Love," and "The Conformist"; Riccardo Bacchelli's "The Mill on the Po"; Vasco Pratolini's "A Tale of Poor Lovers" and "A Hero of Our Time"; Giuseppe Berto's "The Sky Is Red" and "The Brigand"; Elio Vittorini's "In Sicily" and "The Twilight of the Elephant"; Ennio Flaiano's "The Short Cut"; Elsa Morante's "House of Liars." Especially when seen from the other side of the Atlantic, and by the writers themselves, all this is simply evidence that English and American critics and publishers have taken cognizance of an Italian literature which until recently they had disregarded. This disregard before the war was due—but in a relatively superficial sense—to the fact that anything that came from a country under totalitarian rule was considered suspect.

Most of the Italian writers who are now well-known in this country and taken to be instances of the postwar revival, like Alberto Moravia, were already recognized in Italy before the war; and while they were trying to manage as well as they could under the exacting circumstances created by civil curtailments, they would probably have welcomed the spiritual support of some sort of American interest. Such support was not then available. On the Italian side, there was considerable, and justified, interest in American literature; the writers

who fostered it, like Elio Vittorini, are partly responsible for the present reception of Italian work in America, because, even in a difficult period, full of discomfort and distress, they kept alive a sense of this art which transcended national boundaries. I think this may be a lesson worth keeping in mind when we now wonder about intellectuals "behind the curtain."

IT would be inaccurate to explain the current shift in attitude toward Italy by saying that postwar Italian literature suddenly became relevant and exciting. It is, of course, true that Fascist oppression and conformism had imposed certain taboos on writers and that postwar freedom from restrictions put at their disposal, among other things, certain themes which either politics or "morals" had made untouchable until then—from crooked politicians to characters committing suicide (forbidden in fiction under Fascism), from crying poverty to brothels, etc. Even pity, in a sense, was forbidden during the regime under which everything, as the well-known saying went, was either forbidden or compulsory; and one writer, defining the eternal "Fascist" traits, once desperately said that every form of intelligence was obviously considered "intelligence with the enemy." It is also true that the ferment created by the war and its aftermath offered new and important visions and experiences to writers. But it is not true that such ferments necessarily bring about a resurgence of creativity: literary standards do not depend on the topicality of themes; and, more importantly, they cannot be improvised.

Thus if we turn to actual writing,

P. M. Pasinetti, a native of Venice, now lives in Los Angeles, where he teaches the course in world literature at UCLA. He is himself working on a novel, set in present-day Venice. The article forms part of "New World Writing," published this week by the New American Library.